Counterparts

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Comments welcome

Contents

Chapter 3

Counterpart theory and the fixity of the qualitative

As you are now, so once was I
As I am now, so will you be

Tomb inscription, attributed to Horace

3.1 Necessary and eternal existence

Unrestrictedly speaking, everything is identical to something. *A fortiori*, every counterpart of anything is identical to something. Thus **??** entails the very controversial claim that, unrestrictedly speaking, each thing is necessarily identical to something:

(NE) $\forall x \Box \exists y (y = x)$.

If we follow the logician's custom of understanding 'exists' as synonymous with 'is identical to something', we get the headline-grabbing claim that *each thing necessarily exists*. This is not a peculiarity of **??**: since every counterpart of anything that is in a Lewis-world is identical to something in that Lewis-world, Lewis's analysis **??** also entails NE. Most philosophers have found this claim extremely implausible. According to them, Prince Charles, for example, could have failed to be identical to anything at all: Queen Elizabeth and Prince Philip could have failed to meet; if so, Prince Charles would never have been conceived; and in that case, there would have been nothing identical to him. This is one of the standard objections to counterpart theory.

A parallel objection could be raised to temporal counterpart theory. Just as **??** entails NE, **??** entails that each thing has always been, and always will be, identical to something (unrestrictedly speaking):

(EE) $\forall x \mathsf{H} \exists y (y = x)$
$\forall x \mathsf{G} \exists y (y = x)$

This is deeply controversial too. It is rejected, influentially, by 'presentists' in the tradition of Prior (1957, 1967, 1968b). However, temporal counterpart theorists who endorse EE have some influential allies, namely those philosophers—temporal B-theorists, for the most part—who take expressions like 'always' to be quantifiers that bind syntactically real variables ranging over times (see section 2.1). Those who think this must perforce take tense operators to be vacuous when applied to sentences that contain no variables for them to bind. And when the quantifier is read as unrestricted, it is hard to see how '$\exists y(y = x)$' could contain any such variables. In the modal case, by contrast, NE is decidedly a minority view, although its popularity has grown somewhat in recent years thanks to the efforts of Zalta and Linsky (1994) and especially Timothy Williamson (1998, 2002, 2010, 2013).

Lewis's reaction to this objection to counterpart theory is quite concessive. He clearly thinks that there is a natural reading of 'Humphrey could have failed to exist' on which it is true iff there are Lewis-worlds that contain no counterparts of Humphrey. But he seems to despair of the task of providing a systematic semantic account of modality in English which explains how the sentence comes to have this reading:

> What is the correct counterpart-theoretic interpretation of the modal formulas of the standard language of quantified modal logic? —Who cares? We can make them mean whatever we like. We are their master. We needn't be faithful to the meanings we learned at mother's knee—because we didn't. If this language of boxes and diamonds proves to be a clumsy instrument for talking about matters of essence and potentiality, let it go hang. Use the resources of modal realism *directly* to say what it would mean for Humphrey to be essentially human, or to exist contingently. (*OPW* 12–13)

I find this passage rather mystifying. True, I didn't learn about '$\Box$' and '$\Diamond$' at mother's knee: but I *did* learn the words 'necessarily' and 'possibly' somewhere thereabouts, and later I was introduced to '$\Box$' and '$\Diamond$' as synonyms for 'necessarily' and 'possibly'. True, the resources of English for talking about modal matters are rich. As well as 'necessarily' and 'possibly', we have more adverbs like 'essentially' and 'contingently', as well modal auxiliaries like 'can' and 'could', adjectives like 'possible' and 'potential', etc. We should be open to learning that not everything that can be said using these resources can be said using 'necessarily' and 'possibly'. But Lewis is not even sketching an approach to semantics of these aspects of English. Rather, it sounds like he is saying that we should be content with one-off accounts of particular sentences and give up on systematic semantics.

In any case, in the light of what we have learned in this chapter, the suggestion that the existence of Lewis-worlds containing no counterparts of Humphrey would be enough to vindicate a true reading of 'Humphrey could have failed to be identical to anything' in which the quantifier is *unrestricted* looks hopeless. That suggestion is inextricably tied to a conception of modality in which quantification over Lewis-worlds play a central role, and in which that role involves providing restrictions for quantifiers, even ones that are originally unrestricted. I have argued that this conception should be replaced by one conforming to **??**. And once we make this replacement, the fact that there are Lewis-worlds containing no counterparts of Humphrey will look completely irrelevant to the truth of 'Humphrey could have failed to be identical to anything, unrestrictedly speaking', even if we are willing to entertain unorthodox ideas about the relation between this sentence and the language of boxes and diamonds.

I think a better option for modal counterpart theorists is to stand their ground and insist that it is just *true*, speaking unrestrictedly, that everything is necessarily identical to something. When unrestricted quantification is in play, modal realists are used to disagreeing with ordinary opinion. Nothing is more familiar to them than claiming, of some intuitively true sentence involving quantifiers, that it is true only when the quantifiers are taken to be somehow restricted. As we have seen, this is bound to happen with sentences like 'It is contingent whether some swans are blue'. Against the backdrop of this pattern of agreement and disagreement with pre-theoretical opinion, it is hard to see that counterpart theorists will incur any *further* costs if they claim, analogously, that 'It is contingent whether something is identical to Humphrey' is false when its quantifier is taken as unrestricted. So long as they agree that the sentence can be made true by interpreting its quantifier as restricted, the dialectical situation is just the familiar one.

And it is easy for counterpart theorists to come up with *restricted* readings of 'something' on which 'It is contingent whether something is identical to Humphrey' is true. For example, 'something' could carry a qualitative restriction, say to things that are *alive*. Then the sentence will be true so long as some but not all of Humphrey's counterparts are alive. Or 'something' could carry a *de re* restriction, say to things on Earth. While we have not yet considered how to analyse multiply *de re* modal claims like 'Possibly, nothing on Earth is identical to Humphrey'—this is a task for chapter 4—there is no reason at all to worry that they will turn out to be false. Or 'something' could carry a *de re* restriction to things in Cosmo. So long as our account of multiply *de re* modality can account for the truth of 'Possibly, nothing on Earth is identical to Humphrey', it will presumably be able to account in a parallel way for the truth of 'Possibly, nothing in Cosmo is identical to Humphrey.' None of these restricted readings of 'It is contingent whether Humphrey is identical to something' seems like a very plausible candidate to be what people actually have in mind when they utter sentences like 'It is contingent whether Humphrey exists'. The word 'exists' does not take so easily to contextual domain restriction as quantifiers proper: for example, I cannot felicitously say 'John does not exist' if all I mean is that John is not at my party. But I was not arguing that counterpart theorists should think of themselves as agreeing with what the folk mean when they say that some things exist contingently; I was merely claiming that the disagreement, while real, is part of a familiar general pattern.

Lewis suggests that, in many ordinary contexts, 'counterpart' expresses a relation that human beings never bear to things that are not human, so that 'Each human being is necessarily a human being' is true. Unlike NE, this claim is not forced on us by the abstract form of the counterpart-theoretic analysis. And since 'counterpart' is certainly not one of the words we learnt at mother's knee, the right way to address the question whether human beings only human counterparts is not to directly consult our "speakers intuitions", but to consider the plausibility of the modal thesis that would follow from this claim. And *prima facie*, the claim that each human being is necessarily human looks rather implausible. Consider Prince Charles, for example. If we thought that it was necessary that he is a human being—an ordinary, flesh-and-blood human being, that is—we would have to say that he *would* have been human even if Queen Elizabeth and Prince Philip had never met (since obviously they *could* have failed to meet). That sounds implausible. Admittedly, our intuition that Charles would not have been human if Elizabeth and Philip had never met is intimately bound up with our temptation to think that there would have been nothing identical to Charles if Elizabeth and Philip had never met. So it is not clear how strongly counterpart theorists who resist that latter temptation should be swayed by the intuition. It is open to them to insist that Charles would still have been a flesh-and-blood human being even if Elizabeth and Philip had never met—perhaps a flesh-and-blood human being living on some planet that is not Earth, in some Lewis-world that is not Cosmo. But this radical claim is certainly not forced upon counterpart theorists. They could also say that Charles would under those circumstances have *failed* to be a flesh-and-blood human being, and indeed that he would have failed to be a physical thing with a mass, a shape, a location in space, etc. They could say, in other words, that Charles could have been *non-concrete*—that is, that that some of his counterparts are non-concrete.

The idea that many concrete objects could have failed to be concrete plays an important role in Williamson's recent work defending NE. Williamson's idea is that ordinary claims about the possibility of things failing to exist are fairly reliable so long as we interpret 'exists' to mean something in the vicinity of 'is concrete', rather than 'is identical to something, unrestrictedly speaking'. The exact meaning of 'concrete' is not so important: the general idea is that non-concrete things are things to which most ordinary, positive, non-modal predicates do not apply. I am inclined to think that proponents of **??** should gratefully avail themselves of Williamson's suggestion. And as regards *temporal* counterpart theory, this seems absolutely crucial. The suggestion that if Elizabeth and Philip had never met, Charles would have been a flesh-and-blood human being living on a different planet was hard to take seriously; the analogous suggestion that *before* Elizabeth and Philip had ever met, Charles already was a flesh-and-blood human being (living on a different planet?) is just embarrassing.[1] But this is the sort of thing we would have to say if we claimed that it has always been the case that Charles is a human being, given that it has not always been the case that Elizabeth and Philip have met.

While "non-concrete" things are boring in many respects, they can have interesting modal and/or temporal properties. Charles has not always been a prince, but even when he was not a prince he was a *future* prince, and even when he has ceased to be a prince he will always be a *former* prince. By the lights of **??**, this means that all Charles's past-counterparts, even the non-concrete ones, have princes among their future-counterparts, and all Charles's future-counterparts have princes among their past-counterparts. I, on the other hand, have never been a future prince, and will never be a

[1] I suppose that believes in the transmigration of souls might take this seriously. But they will not like the analogous claims about inanimate objects.

past prince. My temporal counterparts, including the non-concrete ones, do not have princes among their temporal counterparts. Non-concrete objects can thus differ from one another as regards which objects they have as counterparts. This poses a challenge to the project of providing a non-circular analysis of temporal counterparthood in terms of something else: the relations we appeal to in the analysis must apply to non-concrete objects, and must make interesting distinctions between them. On Williamson's conception of non-concrete objects, this challenge is insuperable. On his picture, there are many distinctions among non-concrete objects that can *only* be captured in a language with temporal or modal operators, or their equivalents. However we should distinguish the general idea that before my birth and after my death I am still identical to something but lack mass, shape, a spatial location, a mental life, etc., from Williamson's own, particularly uncompromising, version of the view. What is needed to avoid absurdity is that a certain range of ordinary predicates (including 'overweight', 'in Oxford', and 'in pain', but not necessarily 'famous' or 'eagerly anticipated') did not apply to currently living beings before their conception, and will not apply to them after their death (and decomposition). This is compatible with the things in question having rich descriptions involving certain "more fundamental" predicates, upon which their temporal counterpart relations supervene.

The claim that ordinary objects have non-concrete objects among their temporal counterparts does not, thus, completely rule out any reductive analysis of temporal counterparthood in other terms, e.g. in terms of spacetime geometry. It does, however, rule out a number of otherwise attractive joint theories about the nature of ordinary objects and temporal counterparthood. Sider, for example, introduced temporal counterpart theory as part of the defence of the idea that ordinary objects are *stages*—three-dimensional spacetime regions, or objects which "occupy" such regions in such a way that no region has more than one "occupant" (Sider 1996). According to Sider, the temporal counterparts of one stage are other stages. And he suggests that the condition that two stages need to meet to be counterparts of one another is the same condition which suffices, according to worm theorists, for them to both to be temporal parts of an ordinary object of a certain kind, where the relevant kind is determined by context. In an ordinary context, then, 'temporal counterpart' expresses a relation that flesh-and-blood people bear only to other flesh-and-blood people: babies, children, and adults. It is not at all obvious how we could modify Sider's theory in such a way that the counterparts of a stage include some other entities to which ordinary "concrete" predicates do not apply. Chapter 6 will investigate some other accounts of the nature of ordinary objects which might be combined with temporal counterpart theory and a spacetime-based fundamental metaphysics.